Chapter Three

The Day After

01 I realize I'm done working on the redline when my hands stop moving. Copying changes from a red-inked engineering drawing to the computer is easy enough to get lost in thought. The music from my brother's old IPod keeps the rhythm in the keys. I pop out one of the yellowed earbuds so the lyrics don't mince the words.

In the title block: DUNSMORE, 04/24/26.

Checked by SAKURASHIMA, 04/24/26. That means I have an excuse to let my crush Kei look at it.

Designed by PRADESH, the guy who keeps giving me these sheets with red scribbles on them, telling me exactly the changes to make, leaving no room for creativity or judgment.

Control-P. Landscape. Tabloid. Margins wide, and black-and-white lines, so the the sheet looks bleaker than the office.

My computer talks to the printer, sounding off a distant whir six rows down. I rise from the cubicle, untucking the collared shirt from my jeans, opposite of what I used to do when I started here. Seems most of my fellow pencil-pushers have settled on the fact that we're not flashy enough to get customer visits. That's for the suit-wearing showmen of the R&D division, off in their hangar.

The paper is warm when it spins two sheets off the press — one copy of my drawing, and one copy of the reference drawing I used from the fifties. The office is so quiet that I can hear it tap against the edge of the tray. It's time for an appraisal on my work, a second set of eyes, and I return to the only other engineer near my age in this division. She's poised at her standing desk when I approach her, focused on a model of a battery enclosure.

"Hey there, Kei," I say.

She lifts a finger. I rest my elbow against the divide of her cubicle. She refuses eye contact, glued to some calculation as her lips move without words. Then she says: "Remember seven and nine-sixteenths."

"Uh . . . got it."

She takes a long pause, her manicured nails clattering against the pink, wireless keyboard. Then she draws several lines on the pad of engineering paper, scribbling several numbers down, halting at the fifth.

"Okay, what was it?"

"Six,"

"Six . . ."

"And . . . twenty-five sixteenths?"

"Twenty-five . . ." She finally looks up at me with her sapphire rings though dark bangs. "What's your problem?"

"Lots of things. Nothing work-related," I say.

"I doubt that," she says, but cracks a smile as she takes the pages into her hands.

"Do you have your Ouija board?" I ask.

"For what?" She asks.

"The person who made this would be a hundred and twenty," I say. "Since we couldn't call them during retirement, I thought I'd try the afterlife."

It gets half a laugh. "I thought seances were for the sales team, always trying to predict our next contract."

"They're able to sell things before we even design them," I say. "How do they do it?"

"I wish I knew. Maybe we could get ahead for once, then." Her eyes return to the page. "So what'd you screw up this time?"

I describe the process.

"You know, I thought Student Government in high school was the end of you asking seniors for help," she says.

"I'd ask one of our lifers if I wanted a senior's ideas. I figured you'd spare me an oral history of hand-drafting."

"Sure." She gestures to the far corner of her desk, stacked neatly with folded sheets. "I'll get to it later today if you add it to the pile."

"Later today?" I ask.

"Yeah."

"It's Friday," I tell her.

"It's not like I have anything else interesting going on," she says.

"So you're staying late again?"

Her oscillating fan wafts her perfume into the air. I'm assaulted with the mental rhyme of a different late Friday, one evening when it was just the two of us, the last Friday of the year before she left for college.

A memory flashes of the club room in high school half a decade ago. It was the night before the summer festival. She was sitting at the desk facing the open window. The wind caught her hair as she stapled strips of construction paper into long chains. I feel my stomach well with the same feeling I felt then, when I realized I was running out of time to make a move, before a whole year would separate us. I remember that stirring feeling of excitement when I approached her, longing for the courage to speak the words.

But she acted first.

The darkness of that room made it feel like the two of us spent an eternity in there, as if she was making up for the whole year I wouldn't see her, for the unrequited connection that began just a little too late. We laid there on the reading couch, facing each other, feeling each other, letting passion pass the hours before the scuttle of the midnight cleaning crew returned us to reality. And then—

"Hello — Earth to Cody?"

I realize I'm watching her lips move instead of listening to her words. "Uh . . . yeah? What?"

"How about the other three things I sent you?"

"Three things? Oh. The redlines, you mean." I scratch the back of my head. "Still in the works. I'm almost done with the second one."

"But it's been like two weeks."

Naveen Pradesh peeks above the wall of his cubicle, and I know exactly what's in store.

"I know. But with the enclosure redesign, I just—"

Nav asks, "How many did you finish today, Cody?"

"I did two of them," I say. "Sir." My voice cracks. "But I had to scan the old drawings through the projector, on the old computer, and..."

"Our team is behind. We need all hands on deck here, or else we're never going to beat all the stuff the machine shop is sending us."

"I know that," I say. "I'll—"

"You need to get in early. And you need to stay the full time. Like Kei: sometimes even longer than eight hours. Just because you're salaried doesn't mean every day can be a half-day."

I nod.

"You want to be on her level, don't you?"

I stumble over the response as that familiar pang of anxiety arrests me. My nails bite the flesh of my palms.

"Y-yeah," I say.

I feel that poisonous feeling rise in my stomach, the same one I felt all those times before, every time my ambition was axed with sharp critique. The words that follow are well-rehearsed.

"I promise I'll do better." I turn to Kei before retreating to my desk. "And thanks. I'll have all your stuff done by the end of Monday."

"End of today, Cody," Nav says.

It takes everything not to give in.

"Sure, boss," I say. "I'm on it."

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02 I retreat to my desk to doom-scroll through social media, trading the personal feeling of apathy for a more global feeling of hopelessness. It fills me with a certain kind of despair when I see all the marriage announcements of friends and acquaintances, like I've continuously been

behind since I never dated in college: not even Kei. I had some fun, but I was too busy for anything meaningful. And as the only child left in my family, my parents beg for grandchildren like I used to beg for sleepovers on the weekends. My profile says I'm single, and it hasn't changed since the end of high school when a different childhood friend and I tried to hit it off. But like Kei and I the year before, it was just too late.

> I can't help but keep scrolling to pass the time. It does little to release the burnout of five continuous hours. If it's not social media, it's something else: endless politics; global warming; celebrity nonsense; social turmoil. And eventually — as I always do — I close the app just to open it again.

> The last sliver of the workday passes. I manage to grind out the third redline a couple minutes before 4:40. I used to get in so early to be ahead of all the others, but now I get in a little after 9:00 and work until everyone else has left, jog my mouse for a while, then either change into gym clothes or head straight home.

> Naveen surprises me before I can pack my bag. He approaches with his backpack over his shoulder, ready to start his weekend.

> "Cody. Make sure you get in early on Monday — I know you tend to get in rather late."

> "Oh, yeah. Sure thing, Nav," I tell him, stuffing down the aftertaste of our exchange. "Is there something before the stand-up meeting? It's not on the calendar."

> "The rest of the team talked about it last night at our Thursday get-together. I was about to leave right now until I realized you weren't there to hear it."

> His expression is distraught. The pang of fear seizes my stomach again.

> "What is it?" I manage.

> "There's a meeting on Monday, nine A.M., about the new contract," he says.

> "We have that in the bag, right?"

> "No. It's not looking good."

"Not good? What does that mean? As in less work? Or..." My stomach turns further with the call of the void. If it's really that, and the grim reaper in HR is sharpening her scythe, I'd think the surprise meeting would have happened today, giving us a weekend to mourn our benefits.

"I'm not sure yet. But I promise you guys will hear anything they tell me."

I swallow. If there's one good thing I can say about him, it's that he's always transparent.

"Sure. Thanks, boss."

"Yeah," he says, shifting the weight of his Jansport backpack, still hanging there as if he's trying to remember something.

I try at humor.

"Hey. If it's catered, I'll get there whenever you want me. You know this company runs on grocery store donuts."

"I'm sure there will be something."

He smirks a little. Feels like joking with my doctor at a well-check, or the cashier's response when the unscanned item should be free.

"There was one more thing," he says, lingering there. "There was something you told me last week . . ." His words are followed by the silence of the empty cubes and the 3D printer's persistent whine. He's trying to remember something, and after a couple seconds of scratching his chin, it finally hits him. "Oh yeah — you get to move into the new place today, is that right?"

"That's right," I say.

"Congratulations."

"Thanks. My parents are helping me unload my stuff. But Mom seems kind of sad, though."

"Sure. Took my wife a while to get over it when Raj left," Nav says. "But he went out of state, though."

"Oh. Nice," I say.

"Off to California."

> "That's cool," I add. "Just like I did."

> "Yeah," he says.

> "Great," I say.

> "Yeah. For Silicon Valley," he says. "Computer science."

> "Wow," I say.

> "Yeah. For some startup. He says he's enjoying it," Nav says.

> "Sweet," I add, completely tapped out on adjectives.

> He shifts the weight of his backpack, steadying his square-frame glasses. "Well, congrats. It's a big step. You've earned it, my friend," he says, with a light smile. "Just don't lift so much this weekend that you sleep in."

> "Yep. Nine A.M. sharp. And free coffee," I say.

> "Always," he says, giving the same thumbs-up he does at the end of any day. "Thanks for getting those redlines done."

> I nod. Then my computer times out from half an hour of inactivity before I can lock it.

> I stare at the reflection, struggling to reconcile what I see. A silhouette of overgrown, short brown hair glares back at me, his stubble long past five-o'clock, roughly combed into a corporate shape. His expression is sunken like melted wax, crescents etched beneath his sockets, and melting further every day.

> Below the monitor, a hefty pile of work is bottomless. I can't bring myself to touch the rest of it today, so instead I hide my head in my hands, trying not to wet my palms with my eyes. A couple minutes pass after the electronic door clicks behind Nav, and another row away, the gentle sound of keystrokes cease their clatter.

> My screen lights with something in the lower-right corner.

SAKURA_KEI 16:57:12:Got a minute?

> I fumble the login twice before I send the reply.

DUNSMO_COD 16:58:21: 👍

> I can hear her heels in the linoleum crossway before she reaches the flourescent-bleached carpet, and I'm quick to wipe my eyes.

"Hey, Cody. I'm sorry I caused all that. I know Nav can be pretty direct about things," Kei says.

"No, it's fine. He's right, and it doesn't bother me . . . but,"

"But what?" She asks.

I perk my ears to the rest of the office, to ensure we're the only ones left. It still comes out as a raucous whisper.

"But I'm just so tired, you know?"

"Of course," she says.

The sadness crystallizes to anger, and I pull a restrained splinter of it out of me. "So when do I get to design something? Where's the industry life that University sold to me? All those senior projects that let us play pretend, tossing us three hundred bucks a team to think up inventions that might change the world. It's no wonder that none of our professors tried living in the real world."

She nods. "No kidding."

"I thought every day in industry would be fun. Hell, I was like one of those graduating preschoolers, you know, saying he wants to be a cop so he can 'shoot bad guys' . . . or whatever it is that Paw Patrol tells your little brothers the criminal justice system is about."

She laughs hard enough to snort. It's too late to cover her mouth. "They're in middle school now, so I don't think they watch that stuff anymore. They're into anime now."

"But all we get to do is fix mistakes. Everything that exists in this company has already been designed, and we're just left with the paperwork."

"I thought you loved paperwork," Kei says. "You were so good at it during our campaign in Student Gov."

"Because you made me do it. That's all a Vice President is good for."

"Please, Cody. You were good at more than that," she says.

My heart almost skips a beat. But she's talking about the work.

"Tell me," I ask. "How long have you been here?"

She counts the seasons on her fingers.

"About three years. Roughly one more than you've been here — because I got out of college a quarter early."

"And when did you move up?"

She seems reluctant, as if it will hurt me.

"Please, just tell me," I ask.

"After . . . a year and two months, but we were busy, you know, and projects kept flowing. They could afford it."

I turn away from the monitor. My eyes settle on the shadow cast by the Space Division building. "I'll get there. And to the next thing, I know. It's just going to be a while."

"You're a good worker. And you're doing fine," she says. I can feel her hand on my shoulder, sending sparks through my nerves. "There's a reason I picked you to run with me."

"So it wasn't just looks," I say. "Or my cultural background. I know I tested well with the Lacrosse Bro demographic."

"You were one of them. But, no, that's not why." She shares a genuine smile. "You should know you're more than any of that," she says, looking at me the same way she used to — but I know better now than to read any further.

"Thanks," I say.

"You should go home. You've been working on that last redline for three days, and now it's over. Call it a week."

"It's only four-thirty," I say. "How long have you been here?"

"Since six or so."

"Well, you're a better woman than I am." Then I add, "Since I'm not." Then I add, "A woman, you know."

"Enough," she laughs. "Go set up your new place. And you know . . . I'd love to stop by and check it out sometime."

My heart skips. "Sure," I say. "And . . ." maybe we could stop by after a movie this weekend?

"And what?" She asks.

"And . . . I'll see you tomorrow."

"You'll see me Monday," she says. "Don't come in tomorrow. Even I won't be here."

"I thought you slept here," I tell her.

"Not on the weekends. Just set your alarm on Sunday: you can't be late again."

She returns to her row. I gather my things, throwing my bag over my shoulder to go home and recover from this exhausting brand of restlessness.

I pass her row of cubes lit by a single light from her pink lamp. She's comfortably buried in the stacks of drawings, and I find a part of me wondering how I ever found the strength to carry that weight.

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03 A Bankers Box is the last thing I have to store away in the small closet beneath the stairs. It's somehow lived to service my family through many moves, and the yellowed white of the cardboard is long-aged to prove it. First is the word OFFICE in my mother's cursive from twenty-some years ago. That was scratched out to say COLLEGE STUFF in my father's handwriting five years ago. Four years later, for the long move back, I amended that with a semicolon, adding ENGINEERING TEXTBOOKS (AND SHIT) in my fine block script to help clarify. And now — so redacted it looks like a square Dalmatian — it reads CODY DUNSMORE, FIRST HOME.

Inside is all the hobby stuff I used to like when I had the energy: a mess of soldering tips, beer-can capacitors and resistors as if I went back to the 90s and robbed a Radio Shack. There's a couple games I picked up when Mom drove me to GameStop for midnight releases with my buddies, and weighing it down is the signed lacrosse ball from the last Varsity game that let me letter in high school.

"You know, for a new home owner, you sure have a lot of crap to start," my father says. "Your mother and I started with nothing. Nothing!"

"But it is a whole lot of nothing." I gesture to the lonely folding chair and cheap television in the small foyer. "The modern man needs very little to be satisfied."

"I just hope it's enough to survive," my mother says. She rubs her temples.

"I'm just glad it comes with a washer and dryer. Otherwise I'd have to buy new clothes every week."

"Dear Lord, Alan. Did we raise him?" She turns to my father. "Did he forget how to wash clothes some time in college?"

"He'll be fine, Kim," Dad says.

It humors us when she gets the panicked look on her face. Neither of us can tell if it's a joke.

"You remember? She's only washed my clothes since I got back from school. I think I remember how to do it."

"But you need to keep your shirts nice. For work," she says. "You need to iron them. Did you get an ironing board?"

"I get it. I know, and I will, tomorrow," I tell her. "You remember I've been working there for two years, right? Everybody just wears jeans. Some even T-shirts."

Dad's face furrows at the thought. "Dressing like that won't get you a promotion."

"Well, they make fun of me when I dress up enough to tuck in my shirt. Saying I'm trying to take their jobs."

"Well, then . . ." Dad starts, but his words trail off.

The silence returns to us: it's a pivotal moment in our relationship. They were empty-nesters for four years, and right when they got used to it, they had me again for another two. The childhood home will be so quiet: maybe it deafens them. I remember my mom kept the room and bed so neat every time I returned from college.

Maybe there are phases to it, just like my late brother's room was all those years ago. It was as still as a museum for months. All his books and participation trophies were scattered thoughtfully as if he had just left the house to go see friends for a really, really long time, his letterman's jacket glistening with pins on the chair, and I almost thought they were planning on putting the whole room behind glass, until one windy day showed them it'd be safer in seventeen boxes.

Cardboard.

Not like the polished wooden box beneath the ground, protecting all the things the war couldn't take.

They head towards the door and turn the knob, still chipper despite how it drags on all of us, and my father wants to show it the least.

I almost think I can hear his voice crack. "Just promise us you'll visit, right? Dinner next week?" And to make it less emasculating, he adds, "Your mother will go nuts if she can't do a load of laundry at least once a month."

"I swear I'll never do it again," she says.

"I promise," I say.

"And maybe you can bring over a girl," Dad says. "Don't get me wrong. You did great in school, but we're never gonna have grandchildren at this rate."

"Oh, Alan," Mom says. I think she's gonna shake her head or admonish him.

But she surprises me.

"You're right. Wasn't there a reason Cody insisted on that queen-size bed?"

"And the spare bedroom. He's smart. Put a bed in there and he's got a fine doghouse."

"Oh. The gaming room, you mean?" I ask, and they're half out the door before Dad answers.

"Lonely girls his age start collecting cats. I just pray you don't do that with games on that computer program you were showing me."

I hold the smile though their words cut me, though they don't realize it.

This isn't the way I wanted this memory to end.

"Maybe you can get that girl from work to come over. The older one you went to prom with. The asian one," Dad says.

"That's enough," I tell him.

I give my mother and father a hug. I squeeze my mother a little longer because she likes them, and I swear I can feel her tremble, just a little, and when they head for the car, my mother chokes on the last words before she'll probably lose it.

"We love you, Cody. We're so proud of you," she says, loud enough that all my new neighbors can hear.

"Thanks. I love you too," I say.

I wave for a while as they depart, blasting the 80s love songs through their windows as my father ducks his head.

I retreat through the threshold of the doorway, hesitating to close the door or else the suddenness of this new chapter might give me whiplash. A couple tears leave my eyes. I sniff. It's a bright March day, and somewhere beyond the spotless windows, the birds sing songs in staccato, coupled with the chattering rumble of new construction.

I flick the lights on, then off, then on again, then settle for off. I sit at the head of the glass dining table to find myself in a familiar headspace, from all those years ago in college, when my roommates left to drive home to their families, and flying for me wasn't an option. In the small closet beneath the stairs is the Bankers Box, and somewhere inside my head I wonder how I can ever reignite those old passions.

I sit there until tinnitus rings in my ears. I don't feel like gaming, going for a walk, or saying hello to the neighbors. I love my parents to pieces, but their words still cut me. I mean, I'm twenty-six years old: is this the age where you start to really believe you'll be alone forever?

The comebacks always come to you long after they're useful. I open the fridge my mom overstocked with frozen food from Costco in case I starve in the next three months and grab an off-brand seltzer, returning to darkness when the door closes.

Then maybe he should have stayed. He was smarter, more attractive, more alive than I can ever be, I could have said. Communication was what killed him. And I refuse to harm my relationship with my parents over it. But really, what do they think? Some neighbor girl is going to stumble in here looking for love?

The thoughts get me nowhere, but the seltzer does. And when the clock reads 8:00 PM, three deep with the gold-painted cans standing like little league trophies on the finely-polished counter, I'm finally able

to forget. And I forget even easier when he stumbles through the open door.

"Beer later, wey. Wanna hotbox my car?"

He slicks his black hair back before dragging his feet on my mat, carrying a rack of cheap beer with an OfficeMax nametag pinned upside-down.